Worker Collective Action and Public Service Delivery: Experimental Evidence from India

In this project, we test a novel approach to improving disadvantaged women's access to NREGA work, the largest public employment guarantee program in the world. Our project uses a randomized experiment to investigate whether the creation of women's 'worker groups' can affect their access to paid work opportunities through NREGA. We partner with an organization, the MGNREGA Watch (MW), based in Bihar, India, that supports disadvantaged women in accessing NREGA employment. MW seeks to create women's 'worker groups' in rural gram panchayats (GPs, or 'village councils'). It trains and supports low-caste and low-income women in collectively working together—from completing the necessary paperwork to petitioning local government officials—in order to increase their access to NREGA employment. In 2021, MW was considering expanding operations to 127 GPs and agreed to randomize within this set. From November 2021 to January 2023, we worked with our partner to randomize their entry into new locations. They prioritized the formation of women's worker groups in treatment areas (64 GPs) over 2 waves, delaying visits to control areas (63 GPs) until after the study. Using this novel randomization, our project asks the following research questions:

- What is the demand for participating in worker groups among disadvantaged women to access better economic opportunities?
- Can women's worker groups improve access to NREGA employment?
- Can women's worker groups improve overall economic and social well-being?

Figure 1: A group of women workers outside government office after submitting a petition under Right to Work (NREGA)